

A FRAMEWORK IN CHAPTERS

Chapter Five

Cisheteropatriarchy

Cisnormativity · Allonormativity · Patriarchy
A Fundamental Matrix

Cisheteropatriarchy is the system that ranks cisgender heterosexual men above everyone else, enforces gender roles and sexual norms, and extracts labour, deference, and reproductive capacity from women, gender-nonconforming people, and LGBTQ+ Nigerians. This chapter runs it through the five domains — from the household to the SSMPA 2014 to the slow death of the woman whose career never developed because the husband's came first.

CONTEXT Nigeria

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CHAPTER 5 OF AN ONGOING FRAMEWORK

Cisheteropatriarchy

Cisheteropatriarchy has three sub-faces, handled here the same way Rankism (Chapter 2) was handled as Archism + Rank + Tenurism. The three faces are **Cisnormativity** (the assumption that everyone is cisgender), **Allonormativity/Repronormativity/Heterosexuality** (the assumption that everyone is allosexual, reproductive, and heterosexual), and **Patriarchy** (male rule).

Cisheteropatriarchy overlaps with Kinship Normativity (Chapter 4) at the marriage dyad and with Rankism (Chapter 2) at the male/female rank. But the three matrices are not the same. Kinship Normativity ranks by blood and marriage. Rankism ranks by position. Cisheteropatriarchy ranks by gender identity, sexual orientation, and gender role. The framework separates them so that each logic can be studied and dismantled on its own terms.

A note on method. The Interpersonal, Disciplinary, and Structural sections take the naive approach — each triad described as if happening for the first time, with no networks, residues, or Canon referenced. The Hegemonic Domain section is where Canon and Practice finally enter the picture.

READING NOTE

Same convention as Chapters 1 through 4. Every paragraph is written to be tweetable. Where you see literal blanks (____), the framework is asking you to write yourself into it. The blanks are the difference between reading about Cisheteropatriarchy and locating yourself inside it.

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SECTION 1

1. Definition: What Cisheteropatriarchy Extracts, Enforces, and Removes

Cisheteropatriarchy is the system that ranks cisgender heterosexual men above everyone else and enforces gender roles and sexual norms. The term draws on three theoretical traditions: bell hooks's *Feminist Theory* (2000) and *The Will to Change* (2004) for patriarchy; Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* (1990) for the performativity of gender; and the trans studies tradition (Serano, Stryker) for cisheteropatriarchy.

The Nigerian feminist tradition is central here. Oyeronke Oyewumi's *The Invention of Women* (1997) argued that 'woman' as a sociological category was imported to Yoruba society by colonial observers, displacing a less rigidly gendered social order. Ifi Amadiume's *Male Daughters, Female Husbands* (1987) documented the Igbo institutions that allowed gender flexibility. Sylvia Wynter's work on coloniality showed how the European gender binary was imposed across the colonial world.

Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie's *We Should All Be Feminists* (2014) translated this analysis for a popular Nigerian audience. Adichie's framing — that gender is a social construction that we can change — is the framework's starting point. Cisheteropatriarchy is not natural. It was built. It can be dismantled.

1.1 The Three Faces

Cisheteropatriarchy is the assumption that everyone is cisgender — that gender identity aligns with sex assigned at birth. The assumption is so deep that most Nigerians have never considered an alternative. The trans Nigerian is invisible at best, pathological at worst. Cisheteropatriarchy is enforced through the binary gender marker on every form, the sex-segregated school, the sex-segregated ward, the sex-segregated toilet.

Alloheterosexuality/Repronormativity/Heterosexuality is the assumption that everyone is allosexual (experiences sexual attraction), reproductive (capable of and interested in reproduction), and heterosexual (attracted to the 'opposite' sex). Adrienne Rich called this 'compulsory heterosexuality' in 1980. The framework treats all three assumptions as a single face because they reinforce each other in practice.

Patriarchy is male rule. The patriarch is the man whose authority structures the household, the institution, the polity. Patriarchy is the oldest of the three faces and the most total in its reach. It supplies the ranking logic that the other two faces depend on: the male ranks above the female, the cis ranks above the trans, the heterosexual ranks above the LGBTQ+. Each ranking is patriarchy's grammar applied to a different axis.

1.2 What Cisheteropatriarchy Extracts

Cisheteropatriarchy extracts five things. First, **domestic labour**: the unpaid physical and emotional work of maintaining the household — cooking, cleaning, laundry, childcare, eldercare — performed disproportionately by women and girls.

Second, **sexual access**: the wife's body is available to the husband on demand. Marital rape was not criminalised in Nigeria until the Violence Against Persons Prohibition Act of 2015, and the criminalisation remains uneven across states. Third, **reproductive capacity**: the wife produces heirs for the husband's lineage, with sons preferred.

Fourth, **emotional labour**: the wife manages the husband's emotions, the children's emotions, and the household's emotional climate. The husband is permitted emotional incompetence; the wife is required to compensate. Fifth, **beauty performance labour**: the wife, the unmarried woman, and increasingly the man perform prescribed beauty standards at material and temporal cost.

1.3 What Cisheteropatriarchy Enforces

Cisheteropatriarchy enforces five standards. First, **heterosexual marriage**: every adult is expected to marry someone of the 'opposite' sex. The Same Sex Marriage Prohibition Act 2014 criminalises any alternative. Second, **binary gender**: every person is male or female, assigned at birth, and unchangeable. There is no legal recognition of non-binary identity in Nigeria.

Third, **gender roles**: the man is the breadwinner, the woman is the caregiver. The man is public, the woman is domestic. The man is active, the woman is receptive. Fourth, **sexual availability to men**: the wife is sexually available to the husband. The unmarried woman is sexually available to male pursuit. The LGBTQ+ Nigerian is treated as available to 'corrective' male violence.

Fifth, **reproductive duty**: the wife must produce children, preferably sons. The childless woman is failed. The woman who refuses motherhood is selfish. The man who refuses fatherhood is unmanly. Each standard is enforced by law, by religion, by the family, and by the interpersonal triads below.

1.4 What Options Cisheteropatriarchy Removes

Concretely, Cisheteropatriarchy removes the option of same-sex marriage — criminalised under SSMPA 2014 with up to 14 years' imprisonment. The LGBTQ+ Nigerian cannot marry their partner, cannot adopt as a couple, cannot have their relationship recognised in any legal form.

It removes the option of gender transition. There is no legal route to gender recognition in Nigeria. The trans Nigerian cannot change their gender marker on official documents. Healthcare for transition is functionally unavailable through the public system.

It removes the option of sexual autonomy. The wife cannot refuse her husband without social sanction. The unmarried woman who is sexually active is shamed. The survivor of sexual violence is held responsible for the violence against her. It removes reproductive autonomy — abortion is criminalised under the Criminal and Penal Codes except to save the mother's life.

It removes the option of refusing marriage. The single adult is deviant. The divorced woman is failed. The widow who does not remarry is suspect. It removes the option of refusing motherhood. It removes the option of women's economic independence — the married woman's career is expected to accommodate the husband's, the children's, and the household's needs first. Each removal is enforced by law, by religion, by the family, and by the triads below.

SECTION 2 · NAIVE APPROACH

2. The Interpersonal Domain

The Interpersonal Domain contains five enforcement triads and five extraction triads. Each is described here as if happening for the first time — no networks, no residues, no Canon. Just the act, the conforming subject, the complicit witness, and (for extraction triads) the Non-Extracting Beneficiary.

3.1 Enforcement Triad: Heterosexual Marriage Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands recognition of heterosexual marriage as the only legitimate conjugal relation. A parent, a religious leader, a relative, or an institution's representative could fill this role. The enforcement is performed by asking 'when are you getting married?', by referring to cohabitation as 'living in sin', by refusing to recognise the same-sex partner, or by punishing those who treat non-marital or same-sex relations as legitimate.

The subject conforms by marrying heterosexually, by hiding the same-sex relation, or by suppressing the non-marital relation. The conforming act is the heterosexual marriage itself in the first case; in the second and third cases, the conforming act is the suppression.

The options the subject loses are concrete. A gay man who marries a woman to conceal his identity loses the option to a life with the partner he actually loves, which is to say, loses the option to a self. A lesbian who is married off to a man loses the same. A cohabiting heterosexual couple loses the right to inherit from each other, the right to make medical decisions, the right to spousal benefits.

The witness is the person who hears the enforcement and says nothing, or who themselves model compliance by being heterosexually married. The witness's complicity normalises the demand. The married witness at the wedding who congratulates the couple on 'doing it the right way' is closing the loop.

3.2 Enforcement Triad: Binary Gender Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands recognition of the gender binary. The parent who demands the gender-nonconforming child dress 'appropriately'. The teacher who insists the boy sit with the boys. The official who refuses to process the trans person's documents because the gender marker does not match the face. The enforcement is performed by direct demand, by misgendering, by deadnaming, or by punishing non-binary presentation.

The subject conforms by performing the assigned gender. The conforming act is the gender performance itself — the dress, the gait, the voice, the mannerism. The trans person who has not transitioned conforms by performing the assigned gender. The trans person who has transitioned conforms by performing the acquired gender. There is no permitted space outside the binary.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The trans person loses the option to be addressed correctly. The non-binary person loses the option to be recognised at all. The gender-nonconforming cis person loses the option to dress and behave as they please without social cost. The child who is gender-nonconforming loses the option to develop without being policed.

The witness is the person who hears the binary enforcement and says nothing, or who themselves perform the binary and so model compliance. The witness's complicity is the shared acceptance that the binary is the natural order.

3.3 Enforcement Triad: Gender Role Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands conformity to prescribed gender roles. The father who demands the son 'man up'. The mother who demands the daughter learn to cook. The husband who demands the wife leave her job. The wife who demands the husband not cry. The enforcement is performed by direct command, by mockery, by withholding approval, or by punishing non-conformity.

The subject conforms by performing the role. The man performs stoicism, economic provision, and sexual assertiveness. The woman performs caregiving, domestic labour, and sexual modesty. The conforming act is the performance itself — the role is the enforcement.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The man who would rather parent than work loses the option to do so without social punishment. The woman who would rather work than parent loses the same. The man who is emotional loses the option to express it. The woman who is ambitious loses the option to pursue it without being marked as 'difficult' or 'mannish'.

The witness is the person who hears the role enforcement and says nothing, or who themselves perform the role and so model compliance. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the family member who consumes the role's products — the son who eats the meal his sister was made to cook, the daughter who receives the school fees her brother was made to earn — without personally commanding the role.

3.4 Enforcement Triad: Sexual Availability Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands the woman's sexual availability. The husband who demands sex on his schedule. The boyfriend who demands sexual access as a test of love. The male stranger who catcalls. The elder who arranges the marriage for the girl. The enforcement is performed by direct demand, by coercion, by sexual violence, or by punishing refusal.

The subject conforms by being available. The conforming act is the availability itself — the woman's body is accessible to the man on his terms. Refusal is punished, sometimes by violence, sometimes by divorce, sometimes by social ruin.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The wife who cannot refuse her husband loses the option to bodily autonomy, which is to say, loses the option to a self that is not owned. The survivor of sexual

violence loses the option to justice — the police, the courts, and the family will blame her. The lesbian who is threatened with corrective rape loses the option to safety.

The witness is the person who hears the availability enforcement and says nothing, or who themselves model compliance by being available or by demanding availability. The witness's complicity is the shared acceptance that women's sexuality is male-regulated. The witness who says 'she was asking for it' is closing the loop.

3.5 Enforcement Triad: Reproductive Duty Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands the woman produce children. The mother-in-law who demands grandchildren. The husband who demands sons. The family elder who demands the lineage continue. The religious leader who demands the couple 'be fruitful and multiply.' The enforcement is performed by asking 'when are you having children?', by punishing childlessness, by arranging fertility treatments, or by punishing abortion.

The subject conforms by reproducing. The conforming act is the pregnancy, the birth, the childrearing. The woman's body is the site. The man's role is to provide the sperm and to oversee. The reproductive duty is enforced regardless of the woman's wishes.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The woman who is required to produce sons loses the option to a body that is not repeatedly pregnant, which is to say, loses the option to health, to career, to life. The childless woman who is pitied loses the option to a complete identity. The woman who does not want children loses the option to refuse without social punishment. The woman who needs an abortion loses the option to a safe one.

The witness is the person who hears the reproductive enforcement and says nothing, or who themselves performed the reproduction for the same family. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the family member whose lineage is being continued by the woman's reproduction — the husband whose name is being carried, the grandfather whose lineage is being extended — without personally commanding the reproduction.

3.6 Extraction Triad: Domestic Labour

The extractor is the person who requires the woman to perform unpaid domestic labour. The husband who expects meals cooked, clothes washed, house cleaned. The mother-in-law who expects the daughter-in-law to serve the household. The parent who expects the daughter to manage the household. The extraction is performed by expectation, by direct command, or by punishing refusal.

The subject conforms by performing. What is extracted is the labour of cooking, cleaning, laundry, childcare, eldercare, and household management. The labour is real. It is the same labour adults perform in paid domestic work, except the wife, daughter, or daughter-in-law is not paid and cannot leave.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The wife who performs domestic labour loses the option to a career of her own, which is to say, loses the option to economic independence. The daughter who manages the household loses the option to her own childhood. The daughter-in-law who serves the household loses the option to rest, to study, to develop her own life.

The witness is the person who watches the domestic labour extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves performed the same labour. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the man of the household who consumes the cooked meals, the clean clothes, the managed children, without personally commanding the labour — though the line between beneficiary and extractor is unstable here, as most husbands drift into extraction over time.

3.7 Extraction Triad: Sexual Access

The extractor is the person who requires sexual access to the woman. The husband who demands sex on his schedule. The boyfriend who demands sexual access as a test of love. The elder who has arranged the marriage for his access. The extraction is performed by direct demand, by coercion, or by sexual violence. Marital rape was not a crime in Nigeria until the VAPP Act 2015.

The subject conforms by being available. What is extracted is the woman's sexual availability — her body's accessibility to the man on his terms. The extraction is unique in that the resource is the subject's body, and the extraction is performed through the body.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The wife who is required to be sexually available loses the option to bodily autonomy, which is to say, loses the option to a self that is not owned. The survivor of marital rape loses the option to refuse without punishment. The survivor of sexual violence outside marriage loses the option to justice and often to physical safety.

The witness is the person who knows of the sexual extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves model compliance by being available. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is rare here because the extraction is personal to the extractor, but the cultural enabler who insists 'a wife must obey her husband' occupies a similar role.

3.8 Extraction Triad: Reproductive Capacity

The extractor is the person who requires the woman to produce children for his lineage. The husband who demands sons. The family elder who demands the lineage continue. The mother-in-law who demands grandchildren. The extraction is performed by asking 'when are you giving us children?', by punishing childlessness, by arranging fertility treatments, or by punishing abortion.

The subject conforms by reproducing. What is extracted is the woman's reproductive capacity — her body's ability to produce an heir, the years of fertility spent in pregnancy and childrearing, the physical and emotional cost of reproduction. The extraction is performed through the body.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The woman who is required to produce sons loses the option to a body that is not repeatedly pregnant, which is to say, loses the option to health, to career, to

life. The childless woman who is pitied loses the option to a complete identity. The woman who does not want children loses the option to refuse. The woman who needs an abortion loses the option to a safe one.

The witness is the person who watches the reproductive extraction and does not intervene. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the family member whose lineage is being continued — the husband whose name is carried, the grandfather whose lineage is extended — without personally commanding the reproduction.

3.9 Extraction Triad: Emotional Labour

The extractor is the person who requires the woman to manage his emotions and the household's emotional climate. The husband who expects the wife to absorb his stress. The father who expects the daughter to soothe his temper. The son who expects the mother to manage his relationships. The extraction is performed by expectation, by direct demand, or by punishing emotional unavailability.

The subject conforms by managing. What is extracted is the labour of listening, soothing, anticipating, absorbing, mediating. The labour is invisible. It does not appear in any economic accounting. But it is real, and it is exhausting, and it falls disproportionately on women.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The wife who manages her husband's emotions loses the option to her own emotional life, which is to say, becomes a kind of emotional servant. The daughter who soothes her father's temper loses the option to a childhood that is not already adult work. The mother who manages her son's relationships loses the option to her own life outside the management.

The witness is the person who watches the emotional labour extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves performed the same labour. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the family member who consumes the emotional labour — the son whose relationships are managed by the mother, the husband whose stress is absorbed by the wife — without personally commanding it.

3.10 Extraction Triad: Beauty Performance Labour

The extractor is the person who requires the woman to perform prescribed beauty standards. The husband who demands the wife wear makeup. The employer who demands the female staff wear heels. The mother who demands the daughter remove her body hair. The peer group that demands the woman maintain a particular body shape. The extraction is performed by direct demand, by social pressure, or by punishing non-conformity.

The subject conforms by performing. What is extracted is the labour and cost of beauty — the time spent on makeup, hair, hair removal, exercise, dieting; the money spent on cosmetics, salon visits, clothes; the bodily cost of restrictive clothing, restrictive eating, and surgical intervention. The labour is invisible. It is performed as 'self-care'.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The woman who performs beauty loses the option to a body that is her own, which is to say, loses the option to comfort, to time, to money, to bodily autonomy.

The woman who refuses beauty loses the option to social acceptance, to employment, sometimes to marriage.

The witness is the person who watches the beauty performance extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves perform the same beauty. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the man who consumes the beauty — the husband whose wife is ‘presentable’, the employer whose female staff ‘look professional’ — without personally commanding the performance.

Nascent forms of this system include: ‘Boys don’t cry’, ‘Man up’, ‘Act like a lady’, ‘That’s gay’, ‘No homo’, ‘You throw like a girl’, ‘She’s asking for it’, Victim-blaming, Slut-shaming, Prude-shaming, ‘Real men don’t...’, ‘Real women do...’, Misgendering, Deadnaming, Corrective rape threats, ‘It’s just a phase’, ‘Who’s the man in the relationship?’, Pressure to perform femininity, Pressure to perform masculinity, Catcalling, Unsolicited advice on women’s bodies, ‘Smile, love’, ‘Women belong in the kitchen’, ‘Men don’t do domestic work’, ‘Boys will be boys’, Treating women as property, Controlling women’s movements, Financial control of women, Policing women’s dress, Policing men’s emotional expression, Mocking men who show vulnerability.

SECTION 3 · NAIVE APPROACH

3. The Disciplinary Domain

When the ten triads above link into networks, Cisheteropatriarchy scales. The link can be hierarchical (the enforcer at one level is the subject at the level above) or community-based (the witness at one triad becomes the enforcer at another). Both forms are visible in every Nigerian institution.

4.1 Disciplinary Hierarchy — Nested Stars

A Disciplinary Hierarchy is a chain of nested triads. The enforcer at one level is the subject at the level above. Each middle position is simultaneously subject above and enforcer below.

Cisheteropatriarchy spreads through this form in every Nigerian institution with a gendered chain of command.

Peak Triad-Node

At the peak is the triad where the highest male authority in the hierarchy enforces on the layer below. The peak enforcer is almost always a man, because Cisheteropatriarchy ranks men at the top. The peak extracts domestic labour, sexual access, reproductive capacity, emotional labour, and beauty performance from the women below, and enforces heterosexual marriage, binary gender, gender roles, sexual availability, and reproductive duty on everyone.

In the patriarchal household, the peak triad is the father enforcing on the mother and children. In the Pentecostal church, the peak is the Bishop enforcing on Senior Pastors (all male), with the parallel all-male hierarchy of Bishops, Pastors, and Deacons. In the mosque, the peak is the Chief Imam enforcing on the congregational Imams. In the university, the peak is the Vice Chancellor enforcing on the layer below. In the military, the peak is the Chief of Defence Staff enforcing on the layer below.

Middle Triad-Nodes

The middle nodes are where the chain's character is clearest. Each middle enforcer is simultaneously subject above and enforcer below. The mother who kneels for the father in the morning demands kneeling from her daughters in the afternoon. The Senior Pastor who kneels for the Bishop at the altar demands kneeling from the deacons at the meeting. The female lecturer who defers to the male HOD demands deference from her female students.

The middle is where Cisheteropatriarchy reproduces. The woman subject of today is the enforcer of tomorrow — as a mother, a mother-in-law, a senior wife, a female supervisor. The middle position teaches the subject to want the position above, which means learning to enforce on those below. By the time the woman becomes a mother-in-law, she has been disciplined by Cisheteropatriarchy for decades.

In the Pentecostal church, the middle nodes run from Bishop down through Senior Pastor, Pastor, Pastor's Wife (parallel female hierarchy), Women's Leader, Women's Fellowship Member, and

Female congregant. The Pastor's Wife enforces Cisheteropatriarchy on the women's fellowship, even as her husband enforces it on the male hierarchy. The system reproduces through women as much as through men.

Bottom Triad-Node

At the bottom is the triad where the lowest-ranked enforcer enforces on the most vulnerable. The husband enforcing on the wife. The mother-in-law enforcing on the daughter-in-law. The senior wife enforcing on the junior wife (in polygynous households). The male student enforcing on the female student in the secondary school. The bottom is where the system's violence is most concentrated.

The bottom node is also where the hierarchy meets the community form. The wife who is enforced on by the husband is simultaneously the enforcer in the women's fellowship at church, where she enforces Cisheteropatriarchy on the younger women. The intersection of hierarchy and community is what makes Cisheteropatriarchy so hard to escape — the subject is enforced on at home and enforces in public.

4.2 Disciplinary Community — Distributed Network

A Disciplinary Community is a distributed network. There is no peak, no chain of command. There is only circulation. The witness of one triad becomes the enforcer, subject, or witness of another. Cisheteropatriarchy spreads laterally through any person who has witnessed gender enforcement without dissenting.

The Mothers-in-Law Network

Cisheteropatriarchy spreads through community by the mothers-in-law network. The senior wife who has absorbed Cisheteropatriarchy for thirty years enforces it on the junior wife who has just married into the household. The junior wife absorbs the enforcement and, when she becomes a mother-in-law herself thirty years later, reproduces the pattern. The chain runs from enforced-on woman to enforcing woman, and the bottom is where the violence is most concentrated.

The Women's Fellowship

Religion amplifies this. The Pentecostal Women's Fellowship circulates the gender role and reproductive duty triads across thousands of households in a single meeting. The fellowship teaches women to be 'virtuous women' — submissive wives, fertile mothers, modest dressers. The teaching is enforced by the fellowship's senior women, who have absorbed the teaching themselves. No central male command issues the order. The pattern circulates by repeated female witnessing.

The Mosque Women's Circle

The mosque women's circle does similar work in Muslim communities. The female teacher (the 'Iya Won' or 'Aunt' in Yoruba Muslim communities, or the equivalent in Hausa and other communities) teaches women to be obedient wives, to dress modestly, to bear children for the lineage. The teaching is enforced by the women themselves on each other.

The Market Women's Association

The market women's association is a community network that does both enforcement and resistance. The association enforces gender roles by expecting women to manage household and trade simultaneously. But the association also gives women economic independence from individual men, which is a partial check on Cisheteropatriarchy. The framework treats both moves as analytically legible: the association is both an enforcement site and a counter-community.

The Gendered Peer Group

The gendered peer group is the most basic community form. The boys' peer group enforces masculinity on each boy, punishing any sign of femininity. The girls' peer group enforces femininity on each girl, punishing any sign of masculinity. The peer group is where Cisheteropatriarchy is learned in childhood, before any adult enforcer shows up.

The secondary school is the textbook case. The boy who is caught showing affection to another boy is ridiculed by his male peers. The girl who is caught being sexually active is shamed by her female peers. The peer group enforces Cisheteropatriarchy on its own members, reproducing the system across generations without any adult command.

SECTION 4 · NAIVE APPROACH

4. The Structural Domain

Run the Ship of Theseus test. When the people in the initial Cisheteropatriarchy triads are dead and replaced, when the networks are disbanded and reform, what is consistent? What outlives both individuals and groups? What forces new individuals and groups to re-form into the same patterns — not because anyone instructs them to, but because the residue makes any other pattern costly or invisible?

Cisheteropatriarchy leaves all three residues. It is one of the most total systems in the framework, alongside Rankism, Adultism, and Kinship Normativity. Almost every Nigerian institution carries Bureaucracy, Stratification, and Classification from Cisheteropatriarchy simultaneously.

5.1 Bureaucracy — Enduring Rules and Procedures

Cisheteropatriarchy's bureaucracy is the codified gender and sexual order. The Marriage Act 1914 codified heterosexual Christian monogamy as the only legally recognised marriage form. The Criminal Code Act 1916, imported wholesale from Victorian English law, codified 'unnatural offences' (Section 214) and 'indecent practices' (Section 217), criminalising same-sex sexual activity with up to 14 years' imprisonment.

The Same Sex Marriage Prohibition Act 2014 (SSMPA) re-codified and expanded the prohibition, criminalising same-sex marriage, same-sex 'amorous relationships,' and even the registration of LGBTQ+ organisations with up to 14 years' imprisonment. The VAPP Act 2015 criminalised some gender-based violence but did not repeal the SSMPA. The Matrimonial Causes Act 1970 codified divorce procedures on the English model.

The gendered passport and ID application process requires women to provide 'father's name' or 'husband's name' in circumstances where men provide only their own. The inheritance laws under customary systems favour male heirs, with daughters often excluded from family property. The tax system treats married women as dependents in some contexts. The NYSC dependency rule allows married women to be posted with their husbands but allows no equivalent for married men.

The Gender and Equal Opportunities Bill has been repeatedly stalled in the National Assembly since 2010, despite passing second reading several times. The bill would codify equal rights for women in marriage, divorce, property, and inheritance. The stall is itself a residue of Cisheteropatriarchy: the legislature reproduces the system by refusing to dismantle it. The original 1914 and 1916 authors are dead. The bureaucracy lives.

5.2 Stratification — Enduring Zero-Sum Rankings

Cisheteropatriarchy's stratification is the daily experience of gender and sexual rank in every institutional encounter. **Male/female in pay** — Nigerian women earn approximately 60% of what men earn for equivalent work, according to the National Bureau of Statistics. **Male/female in promotion** — women are under-represented at every management level in Nigerian corporate and public sectors.

Male/female in political representation — women held approximately 4% of National Assembly seats after the 2023 elections, one of the lowest representation rates in Africa.

Heterosexual/cisgender vs LGBTQ+ — the LGBTQ+ Nigerian is below the legal horizon, criminalised and invisible. **Men at the top of religious hierarchies** — the Catholic priesthood, the Pentecostal pastorate, the Imams are exclusively male.

Male-only stools in some traditional systems — the stool of the Oba of Benin, the Sultan of Sokoto, the Emir of Kano are male-only, despite the existence of female political leaders in pre-colonial Nigerian history (Queen Amina of Zaria, the Iyalode of Ibadan, the Omu of Onitsha). The ranking is in the air; it does not need to be announced.

The family event enforces stratification without anyone issuing an order. The patriarch sits at the head of the table. The adult men sit next. The adult women sit next. The children sit by age and sex. The wives serve the men. The seating is the rank. Challenging the seating is challenging the gender order.

5.3 Classification — Enduring Categorical Divisions

Cisheteropatriarchy's classification is the set of categorical names that organise every Nigerian into gender and sexual categories. **Male** and **female** on every form — birth certificate, passport, school registration, voter card. There is no third option. **Masculine** and **feminine** as moral categories — the 'effeminate' man and the 'mannish' woman are marked as deviant.

Husband and **wife** — the conjugal pair with the husband as head. **Father** and **mother** — the parental pair with the father as authority. **Son** and **daughter** — the child pair with the son as heir.

Heterosexual and **homosexual** — the sexual pair with heterosexual as the default and homosexual as the criminal.

Normal and **abnormal** — the moral pair with cisgender heterosexual as normal and everyone else as abnormal. **Real man** and **real woman** — the policing pair that marks non-conforming cis people as insufficiently masculine or feminine. The classification does the work before any individual enforcer shows up.

A woman walking into a bank to open an account is already classified; the officer may ask for her husband's permission. A trans person walking into a clinic is already classified; the clinician may refuse care. A gay man walking into a police station to report extortion is already classified; the officer may arrest him. Classification is the most universal structural residue. Cisheteropatriarchy's classification is the foundational binary — male/female — that organises almost every other classification in the framework.

SECTION 5

5. The Hegemonic Domain: The Ascension Ritual

Is Cisheteropatriarchy ascended? Yes on all three counts. It produces all three structural residues including Stratification (so Internalised Domination applies). It has working Canon and Practice mechanisms. The vast majority of Nigerians cannot imagine a society without the gender binary, without heterosexual marriage, without male authority — despite the fact that pre-colonial Nigerian gender systems were markedly more flexible, and the fact that the current arrangement was installed by specific colonial legal instruments within living memory.

6.1 Canon — Rewriting History

Canon is the present belief that cisheteropatriarchy has always been so. The origination of the structural residues — the Marriage Act 1914, the Criminal Code 1916, the SSMPA 2014 — has been forgotten. The average Nigerian now takes the gender binary, heterosexual marriage, and male authority as natural, eternal, and without alternative.

What is forgotten? Oyeronke Oyewumi's argument that 'woman' as a sociological category was imported to Yoruba society by colonial observers, displacing a less rigidly gendered social order. The Igbo female husband institution, documented by Ifi Amadiume, in which a woman could marry another woman and the offspring carried the wife's lineage. The Yoruba recognition of the Iyalode, the female chief who represented women in the king's council.

Also forgotten: the pre-colonial Nigerian women political leaders — Queen Amina of Zaria (16th century), the Iyalode of Ibadan, the Omu of Onitsha. The colonial encounter treated these as anomalies and largely erased them from the historical record that the colonial schools taught. The post-colonial school curriculum continued the erasure.

Also forgotten: that the Criminal Code's prohibition on 'unnatural offences' was imported from Victorian English law in 1916. That the SSMPA 2014 was a recent legislative act, not an ancient prohibition. That the British themselves decriminalised homosexuality in 1967, while the Nigerian law they left behind remained in force. The Canon presents the prohibition as Nigerian tradition; the history shows it as a colonial inheritance that the coloniser has since discarded.

Internalised Domination

Canon produces Internalised Domination because Cisheteropatriarchy produces Stratification. The man's felt entitlement to domestic labour, sexual access, deference, and decision-making authority is now natural, automatic, unquestionable. The husband who expects meals cooked does not experience this as a demand. He experiences it as the natural order.

The cisgender heterosexual's entitlement to social default is also natural. The cis heterosexual does not experience their gender and sexual recognition as privilege. They experience it as the way things are. The trans or LGBTQ+ Nigerian's existence is treated as a deviation from a natural order, when in fact it is a deviation from a colonial legal order imposed in 1916 and re-imposed in 2014.

The entitlement grows with repetition. The first time the wife did not have dinner ready, the husband felt surprise. The hundredth time, the husband feels outrage. The entitlement has been internalised so deeply that its non-fulfilment registers as injury. Pierre Bourdieu, in *Masculine Domination* (2001), called this the 'paradox of the relative permanence of symbolic asymmetries' — the asymmetry persists because those who benefit from it have stopped noticing it.

Internalised Authority

Canon produces Internalised Authority in the male enforcer regardless of personal material gain. The father who beats the daughter for 'disrespectful' behaviour toward a man gains nothing material from the beating. The husband who punishes the wife for 'disobedience' gains nothing material. The religious leader who condemns the LGBTQ+ Nigerian from the pulpit gains nothing material. The right to enforce feels natural, automatic, and legitimate.

The male stranger who catcalls the woman in the street gains nothing material. The uncle who humiliates the niece for 'not dressing like a woman' gains nothing material. The peer who mocks the gender-nonconforming boy gains nothing material. Each is exercising internalised authority — the felt right to enforce the gender and sexual order regardless of personal gain.

Internalised Oppression

Canon produces Internalised Oppression in the woman subject, the LGBTQ+ subject, and the trans subject. The woman is taught that she cannot refuse her husband. The LGBTQ+ Nigerian is taught that they are sinners. The trans Nigerian is taught that they are confused. The teaching is silent; it is in the air.

The wife who is told by her mother 'endure it, marriage is endurance' is being disciplined by Canon. The lesbian who is told by her pastor 'pray away the spirit' is being disciplined by Canon. The trans man who is told by his doctor 'it is just a phase' is being disciplined by Canon. Each internalises the impossibility of refusal.

The deepest form of this is the woman, LGBTQ+ person, or trans person who has absorbed Cisheteropatriarchy so thoroughly that they enforce it on themselves. The wife who says 'a good wife obeys' to explain why she will not leave the abusive husband. The LGBTQ+ Nigerian who says 'I am a sinner' to explain why they will not pursue a relationship. The trans Nigerian who says 'I am confused' to explain why they will not transition. The rebellion-capable subject has become the self-policing subject.

6.2 Practice — Rewriting Reality

Practice is the second mechanism of the Ascension Ritual. The interpersonal triad is repeated, again and again, until it becomes habit. The male enforcer forgets he can choose not to enforce. The female subject forgets she can rebel. The LGBTQ+ subject forgets they can exist. The middle-aged parent who has been both subject and enforcer forgets they were ever either.

Pierre Bourdieu called this *habitus* — the sediment of repeated practice in the body, such that the social order no longer needs conscious compliance because it has become the body's default. The Nigerian girl who learns to cook at age eight while her brother plays is undergoing Practice for Cisheteropatriarchy. The body learns. The mind stops questioning.

By the time the girl is twelve, the gender role is reflex. She does not decide to cook. The body cooks. By adulthood, the woman has performed the domestic labour, emotional labour, beauty performance, and sexual availability triads so many thousands of times that the alternative — refusing the husband, leaving the kitchen, wearing comfortable clothes — feels like a kind of amputation. The body has been trained. Practice has rewritten reality.

Death — Fast and Slow

Practice produces Death. Fast death in Cisheteropatriarchy is spectacular: so-called 'honour' killings of women who marry outside family approval or who are raped. Corrective rape of lesbians, with documented cases across Nigeria. Mob violence against suspected gay men, enabled by the SSMPA 2014 and its public signalling that LGBTQ+ Nigerians are outside the law's protection. The killing of LGBTQ+ Nigerians with impunity.

Femicide in intimate partner violence — the wife killed by the husband, the girlfriend killed by the boyfriend, with the police often treating the case as a 'family matter.' The kidnapping of schoolgirls by Boko Haram — Chibok 2014 (276 girls), Dapchi 2018 (110 girls) — as both gendered and religious violence. The girls were taken because they were girls in school; the gendered coding is explicit in Boko Haram's own statements.

Slow death in Cisheteropatriarchy is quiet. Chronic stress from constant surveillance of women's bodies and movements. Mental health collapse from years of domestic servitude. The trans Nigerian unable to access healthcare. The LGBTQ+ Nigerian in internal exile, performing heterosexuality in public and existing in fragments in private.

The woman ground down by the male breadwinner's expectation of deference. The woman whose career never develops because the husband's career comes first — she moves cities for his promotion, leaves her network for his job, raises the children while he travels, and reaches 50 with no economic independence. The gender-nonconforming Nigerian subject to daily microaggressions that accumulate into a body that cannot rest. None of these make the news. They are Cisheteropatriarchy's quiet tax.

Ruth Wilson Gilmore's definition applies: Cisheteropatriarchy produces group-differentiated vulnerability to premature death. The groups are women, LGBTQ+ Nigerians, trans Nigerians, and gender-nonconforming Nigerians. The premature death is fast (honour killing, corrective rape, mob violence, femicide, kidnap) or slow (stress, breakdown, internal exile, career collapse, microaggression accumulation). Every ascended matrix kills. Cisheteropatriarchy kills those whose

gender and sexuality do not fit.

SECTION 6

6. When Did Cisheteropatriarchy Rewrite History?

The framework's historical question: when did Cisheteropatriarchy rewrite history in popular Nigerian living memory, such that the average Nigerian cannot recall a time when its structural residue was not present? This is not a history of how Cisheteropatriarchy was built. It is a diagnosis of when the building was forgotten.

Pre-colonial Nigerian gender systems varied. Oyewumi's argument that Yoruba society was less rigidly gendered than colonial observers claimed is contested, but the broader point holds: pre-colonial Nigerian societies had more gender flexibility than the colonial import. The Igbo female husband, the Iyalode, the Omu, the queen mothers, the women's councils — these were not deviations from a natural order but features of different arrangements.

Colonial codification displaced these arrangements from legal recognition. The Marriage Act 1914 imported English Christian monogamy as the only legally recognised marriage form for civil purposes. The Criminal Code Act 1916 imported Victorian prohibitions on 'unnatural offences.' The colonial school curriculum, modelled on the English curriculum, taught the gender binary as natural. The colonial church taught patriarchal Christianity. The colonial administration excluded women from formal political participation.

Post-independence replication continued the displacement. The Criminal and Penal Codes retained the colonial prohibitions. The Marriage Act and Matrimonial Causes Act retained the colonial marriage model. The school curriculum retained the colonial gender model. The SSMPA 2014 was a re-codification, not an innovation — it expanded the existing colonial prohibition, but the prohibition itself was already in place.

The tipping point in popular living memory: **circa 1916** for the legal codification of Victorian sexual morality, and **circa 1914** for the Marriage Act's import of Christian monogamy. For Nigerians born after 1900 — the colonial-subject generation and after — Cisheteropatriarchy has 'always been' in its legal form. The pre-colonial gender-flexible generation (born ~1850s–1880s) was the last to have living memory of indigenous arrangements as the legal default. By 1916, the colonial definition had displaced them in legal recognition, though they survived in practice in many communities.

What changed in that moment? Two things. First, the Criminal Code 1916 standardised the Victorian prohibition on same-sex sexual activity as the legal default, so that the colonial definition of 'normal' sexuality became the legal definition for every Nigerian. Second, the colonial courts began to enforce this definition in criminal cases, so that the first generation to live their adult lives under the new regime reached adulthood in the 1920s and 1930s. By 1960, the question 'is the gender binary natural?' had stopped being asked in popular memory.

SECTION 7

7. Fill in the Blank: A Self-Examination

The framework asks two questions of every subject of every ascended matrix. The blanks are for you. They are not rhetorical. The point of the framework is not to understand Cisheteropatriarchy in the abstract. It is to locate yourself inside it, so that the next time the triad assembles around you — or around someone whose gender or sexuality does not fit — you can see it.

Question 1: When did Cisheteropatriarchy rewrite your reality?

When did the system teach you that you could not rebel? The moment was: _____. The year was: _____. The person who first made you feel that challenging them was impossible was: _____. The place was: _____. What you wanted to say but did not was: _____. What you did instead was: _____. What you told yourself about why you did not say it was: _____. The gender performance you assumed in that moment was: _____. The form of address you used was: _____. What you lost, in that moment, that you have not got back since, was: _____. The gender or sexual category at the centre of the moment was: _____.

Question 2: How is Cisheteropatriarchy causing your Death?

How is the system shortening your life right now? The form of Death I am most afraid of from Cisheteropatriarchy is (fast/slow): _____. The specific way it is happening in my body is: _____. (For example: the chronic stress from years of being sexually harassed at work; the insomnia from years of swallowing words I wanted to say to my husband; the loss of confidence from years of being told I am 'too ambitious'; the breakdown I had in 20__ that I have never fully recovered from; the relationship I lost because I could not stop performing femininity at home; the medical diagnosis I now live with because the stress had nowhere else to go; the internal exile I am in because my sexuality cannot be spoken; the healthcare I cannot access because my gender cannot be acknowledged.) The matrix's name for what is happening to me is: _____. My own name for it is: _____.

If you filled in the blanks honestly, you have just located yourself inside Cisheteropatriarchy. The next time the triad assembles — the next time the father demands, the next time the wife performs, the next time the LGBTQ+ Nigerian is silenced — you will be able to see the system moving through you. That sight is the beginning of abolition. And if you are now the enforcer in the triad, the sight is also the beginning of your refusal to enforce.

SECTION 8

8. Endnotes & References

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Coming Next

Chapter 6 will take up Religious Dominance / Sectarianism — the system that ranks adherents of one religion above others, enforces religious conformity, and extracts loyalty, financial contribution, and political support from adherents. Religious Dominance overlaps with Cisheteropatriarchy at the point of religious family law (Chapter 5) and with Rankism at the point of religious hierarchy (Chapter 2). The framework separates it so that the religious-identity logic specifically can be studied and dismantled.

If you are reading this chapter as part of the framework in progress, the order continues: Chapter 7 is Enclosure, Chapter 8 is Productivism, Chapter 9 is Invasion, and so on through the Fundamental Matrices. Each chapter follows the same template established in Chapters 2, 3, 4, and 5. The naive approach in the first three domains. The Ascension Ritual in the fourth. The historical memory trace. The fill-in-the-blank. The endnotes. The pattern is now set.